

P2447R6

std::span over an initializer list

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LWG

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8

Abstract

`span<const int>` can be a lightweight drop-in replacement for `const vector<int>&` in the same way that `string_view` can replace `const string&`. While `"abc"` binds to a `string_view` function parameter, `{1, 2, 3}` fails to bind to a `span<const int>` function parameter. We show why this gap is undesirable, and propose to close it, ideally as a DR.

Table of Contents

1 Changelog

2 Background

3 Solution

3.1 Implementation experience

3.2 What about dangling?

3.3 Why not just double the braces?

3.3.1 Better performance via synergy with P2752

4 Breaking changes

5 Straw polls

6 Proposed wording

7 Acknowledgments

References

§ 1. Changelog

- R6 (post-Kona 2023):
 - Remove the constructor's `noexcept`, because it has a precondition. An LWG issue will be filed to remove the `noexcept` on `[[span.cons]/20]`(<https://eel.is/c++draft/span.cons#20>).
- R5 (post-LEWG 2023):
 - Reintroduce feature-test macro `__cpp_lib_span_initializer_list`.
 - Add Annex C entries to [§ 6 Proposed wording](#); LEWG points out that it's easy for LWG to eliminate insertions they deem redundant.
- R4 (pre-Varna 2023):
 - Reorganize references to [\[P2752\]](#) and fix HTML goofs in proposed wording.
- R3:
 - Changed primary authorship from Federico Kircheis to Arthur O'Dwyer.
 - Removed R2's feature-test macro `__cpp_lib_span_init`; it didn't seem motivated.
- R2:
 - Discussed in LEWG telecon, [2022-07-26](#)

§ 2. Background

C++17 added `string_view` as a "view" over constant string data. Its main purpose is as a lightweight drop-in replacement for `const string&` function parameters.

C++14 <code>string</code>	C++17 <code>string_view</code>
<pre>int take(const std::string& s) { return s[0] + s.size(); }</pre>	<pre>int take(std::string_view sv) { return s[0] + s.size(); }</pre>
<pre>std::string abc = "abc"; take(abc);</pre>	<pre>std::string abc = "abc"; take(abc);</pre>
<pre>take("abc");</pre>	<pre>take("abc");</pre>
<pre>take(std::string("abc"));</pre>	<pre>take(std::string("abc")); take(std::string_view("abc"));</pre>

C++20 added `span<const T>` as a "view" over constant contiguous data of type `T` (such as arrays and vectors). One of its main purposes (although not its only one) is as a lightweight drop-in replacement for `const vector<T>&` function parameters.

C++17 <code>vector</code>	C++20 <code>span</code>
<pre>int take(const std::vector<int>& v) { return v[0] + v.size(); }</pre>	<pre>int take(std::span<const int> v) { return v[0] + v.size(); }</pre>
<pre>std::vector<int> abc = {1,2,3}; take(abc);</pre>	<pre>std::vector<int> abc = {1,2,3}; take(abc);</pre>
<pre>take({1,2,3});</pre>	
<pre>take({}); // size=0 take({{1,2,3}}); take(std::vector{1,2,3}); take(std::initializer_list<int>{1,2,3});</pre>	<pre>take({}); // size=0 take({{1,2,3}}); take(std::vector{1,2,3}); take(std::initializer_list<int>{1,2,3}); take(std::span<const int>({1,2,3}));</pre>

This table has a conspicuous gap. The singly-braced initializer list `{1,2,3}` is implicitly convertible to `std::vector<int>`, but not to `std::span<const int>`.

§ 3. Solution

We propose simply that `std::span<const T>` should be convertible from an appropriate *braced-initializer-list*. In practice this means adding a constructor from `std::initializer_list`.

§ 3.1. Implementation experience

This proposal has been implemented in Arthur's fork of libc++ since October 2021. See "[span should have a converting constructor from initializer_list](#)" (2021-10-03) and [\[Patch\]](#).

§ 3.2. What about dangling?

`span`, like `string_view`, is specifically designed to bind to rvalues as well as lvalues. This is what lets us write useful code like:

```
int take(std::string_view s);
std::string give_string();
int x = take(give_string());

int take(std::span<const int> v);
std::vector<int> give_vector();
int x = take(give_vector());
```

Careless misuse of `string_view` and `span` outside a function parameter list can dangle:

```
std::string_view s = give_string(); // dangles
std::span<const int> v = give_vector(); // dangles
```

P2447 doesn't propose to increase the risk in this area; dangling is already likely when `span` or `string_view` is carelessly misused. We simply propose to close the ergonomic syntax gap between `span` and `string_view`.

Before	After P2447
<pre>std::string_view s = "abc"; // OK std::string_view s = "abc"s; // dangles std::span<const char> v = "abc"; // OK std::span<const char> v = "abc"s; // dangles</pre>	<pre>std::string_view s = "abc"; // OK std::string_view s = "abc"s; // dangles std::span<const char> v = "abc"; // OK std::span<const char> v = "abc"s; // dangles</pre>
<pre>std::span<const int> v = std::vector{1,2,3}; // dangles auto v = std::span<const int>({1,2,3}); // dangles std::span<const int> v = {{1,2,3}}; // dangles</pre>	<pre>std::span<const int> v = std::vector{1,2,3}; // dangle auto v = std::span<const int>({1,2,3}); // dangle std::span<const int> v = {{1,2,3}}; // dangle std::span<const int> v = {1,2,3}; // dangle</pre>

§ 3.3. Why not just double the braces?

Since we can already write

```
std::span<const int> v = {{1,2,3}}; // dangles
```

then why not call that "good enough"? Why do we need to be able to use a single set of braces?

Well, a single set of braces is good enough for `vector`, and we want `span` to be a drop-in replacement for `vector` in function parameter lists, so we need to support the syntax `vector` does. There was a period right after C++11 where some people were writing

```
std::vector<int> v = {{1,2,3}};
```

but by C++14 we had settled firmly on "one set of braces" as the preferred style (matching the preferred style for C arrays, pairs, tuples, etc.)

So I prefer to turn the question around and say: Since we can already implicitly treat `{{1,2,3}}` as a `span`, how could there be any additional harm in treating `{1,2,3}` as a `span`?

§ 3.3.1. Better performance via synergy with P2752

[P2752], adopted as a DR at Varna 2023, allows a constant `initializer_list` like `{1,2,3}` to refer to a backing array in static storage, rather than forcing all backing arrays onto the stack. This doesn't change anything dangling-wise: referring to the backing array of an `initializer_list` outside that `initializer_list`'s lifetime remains undefined behavior.

```
std::string_view s = "abc"; // OK, no dangling
std::span<const int> v1 = {1,2,3}; // dangles, even after P2752
```

Today, `{{1,2,3}}` converts to `span` by materializing a temporary `const int[3]` on the stack. Tomorrow, if P2447 is adopted, `{1,2,3}` will convert to `span` via an `initializer_list` that refers to a backing array in static storage. In other words, the `initializer_list` constructor we propose here in P2447 is "more optimizer-friendly" than today's array-temporary constructor.

This example ([Godbolt](#)) shows how P2447 lets us benefit from P2752’s optimization:

```
int perf(std::span<const int>);

int test() {
    return perf({{1,2,3}});
}
```

	<code>{{1,2,3}}</code>	<code>{1,2,3}</code>
Before 2752	Array on stack	Ill-formed
Today	Array on stack	Ill-formed
P2447	IL in rodata, tail-call	IL in rodata, tail-call

In each row, there’s no performance difference between the single-braced or double-braced form. But the only way to reach the bottom row (tail-call, no stack usage) in *either* column is to adopt P2447, which by a happy coincidence also permits the single-braced form.

§ 4. Breaking changes

This change will, of course, break some code (most of it pathological). We propose adding three new examples to Annex C. But *any* change to overload sets can break code, and sometimes LWG doesn’t bother with an Annex C entry. For example, C++23 adopted [\[P1425\]](#) "Iterator-pair constructors for `stack` and `queue`" with no change to Annex C, despite its breaking code like this:

```
void zero(queue<int>);
void zero(pair<int*, int*>);
int a[10];
void test() { zero({a, a+10}); }
```

- Before:** Calls `zero(pair<int, int>)`.
- After P1425:** Ambiguous.
- To fix:** Eliminate the ambiguous overloading, or cast the argument to `pair`.

Therefore, we’re happy for LWG to eliminate any or all of our proposed Annex C entries if they’re going too far into the weeds.

For explanation and suggested fixits for each of the Annex C examples included in [§ 6 Proposed wording](#), see [P2447R4 §4](#).

§ 5. Straw polls

P2447R4 was presented to LEWG on 2023-09-12. The following polls were taken. The first was classified as "no consensus," the second as "weak consensus."

	<i>SF</i>	<i>F</i>	<i>N</i>	<i>A</i>	<i>SA</i>
<i>Forward P2447R4 to LWG for C++26 and as a defect.</i>	2	5	3	2	1
<i>Forward P2447R4 to LWG for C++26 (not as a defect).</i>	2	6	4	1	1

§ 6. Proposed wording

Modify [\[span.syn\]](#) as follows:

```
#include <initializer_list>      // see [initializer.list.syn]
```

Modify [\[span.overview\]](#) as follows:

```
template<size_t N>
    constexpr span(type_identity_t<element_type> (&arr)[N]) noexcept;
template<class T, size_t N>
    constexpr span(array<T, N>& arr) noexcept;
template<class T, size_t N>
    constexpr span(const array<T, N>& arr) noexcept;
template<class R>
    constexpr explicit(extent != dynamic_extent) span(R&& r);

constexpr explicit(extent != dynamic_extent) span(std::initializer_list<value_type> il);
constexpr span(const span& other) noexcept = default;
template<class OtherElementType, size_t OtherExtent>
    constexpr explicit(see below) span(const span<OtherElementType, OtherExtent>& s) noexcept;
```

Modify [\[span.cons\]](#) as follows:

```
constexpr explicit(extent != dynamic_extent) span(std::initializer_list<value_type> il);
```

Constraints: `is const v<element_type> is true`.

Preconditions: If `extent` is not equal to `dynamic_extent`, then `il.size()` is equal to `extent`.

Effects: Initializes `data` with `il.begin()` and `size` with `il.size()`.

Modify [\[diff.cpp26\]](#) as follows:

NOTE: For explanation and suggested fixits for each of these examples, see [P2447R4 §4](#). My understanding is that Annex C wording shouldn't contain that extra material.

[containers]: containers library.

1. Affected subclause: `[span.overview]`

Change: `span<const T>` is constructible from initializer list `<T>`.

Rationale: Permit passing a braced initializer list to a function taking `span`.

Effect on original feature: Valid C++ 2023 code that relies on the lack of this constructor may refuse to compile, or change behavior. For example:

```
void one(pair<int, int>); // #1
void one(span<const int>); // #2
void t1() { one({1,2}); } // ambiguous between #1 and #2; previously called #1

void two(span<const int, 2>);
void t2() { two({{1,2}}); } // ill-formed; previously well-formed

void *a[10];
int x = span<void* const>{a, 0}.size(); // x is 2; previously 0
any b[10];
int y = span<const any>{b, b+10}.size(); // y is 2; previously 10
```

Add a feature-test macro to [\[version.syn\]/2](#) as follows:

```
#define __cpp_lib_span 202002L // also in <span>
#define __cpp_lib_span_initializer_list XXYYZZL // also in <span>
#define __cpp_lib_spanstream 202106L // also in <spanstream>
```

§ 7. Acknowledgments

- Thanks to Federico Kircheis for writing the first drafts of this paper.
- Thanks to Jarrad Waterloo for his support.

§ References

§ Informative References

[P1425]

Corentin Jabot. *Iterator-pair constructors for stack and queue*. March 2021. URL: <https://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2021/p1425r4.pdf>

[P2752]

Arthur O'Dwyer. *Static storage for braced initializers*. June 2023. URL: <https://www.open-std.org/jtc1/sc22/wg21/docs/papers/2023/p2752r3.html>

[Patch]

Arthur O'Dwyer. *Implement P2447 `std::span` convertible from `std::initializer_list`*. October 2021. URL: <https://github.com/Quuxplusone/llvm-project/pull/17>